# My Interrail Experience

# Krakow - Bratislava - Budapest - Vienna

Pai Doose

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# 1 Introduction

Hey there,
my name is Pai and I participated in an Interrail tour sponsored by the European Commission under the banner of #DiscoverEU and organized by the IJBK e.V.. I became aware of this project when I saw a poster in our cafeteria and decided instantly to apply with a friend of mine, Lara. After a while the two of us got an E-Mail saying that we got the opportunity to join and that there was still room for one more participant. That's how our friend Amy came to join. As a group of three we chose to sign up for the same out of three routes given to us.
Our Route was Kaiserslautern - Krakow - Bratislava - Budapest - Vienna - Kaiserslautern. Since every travel group consists out of 5 participants of the age of 21 or younger and one group leader younger than 30 we were excited when we finally got to meet our group in person a week before departure. It consisted out of the Nikhil or Nik, a really warm and open person, Zheng who came to Europe only 5 months before from china and wasn't that comfortable with the western culture yet and Camille or group leader, a French women always with a smile on her face. That's us! And with them together I hoped to explore Europe, learn new things about different cultures and history and of course try some traditional recipes from the countries we will travel.
How much of this I actually got to do and how our journey turned out is written on the following pages...

## 2 Day 1 - Travel to Krakow

6 a.m. meetup at Kaiserslautern Hbf.

We started our journey together with all of the other travel groups with a rail replacement transport and of course with a good Deutsche Bahn delay of twenty minutes. In Mannheim we split from the group travelling to Ljubjana, the other group headed to Prague took the same train as we did to Mannheim. After arriving at the Mannheim train station we finally had to say goodbye to the Prague travellers.
While spending an hour at the Mannheim Hbf Lara introduced us to a travel card game, where you get a travel challenge everyday. Mine was to walk barefoot most of the day, which of course wasn't really possible to do.
After boarding our ICE to Berlin Nik completed his task by giving a compliment to a total stranger, who was really happy about it, because it came so unexpectedly. That reminded all of us how easy it is to make someone's day a bit brighter with just a few tiny words.
During our trip Camille our Group leader was working on her challenge as well by teaching

us five words french. 'Fleurir' was the first word meaning to blossom or 'blühen' in german. Later that day we learned the words 'sac a dos' - backpack, 'charite' - charity and two more which I've forgotten by now.
Having two hours transfer time in Berlin we took the subway to the Brandenburger Gate. In front of the Brandenburger Gate we saw a german online 'celebrity' called "die militante Veganerin" during her protest action against eating meat.

In front of the Reichstag, Lara did her challenge drawing a sand castle in the sand.
Camille supported the drawing by adding a dangerous dragon as well.
Shortly before our departure to , Camille got to eat her first original Berlin Döner, which fulfilled her wish for our time in Berlin.
Our seven hour ride to Krakow we spent by listening to music, talking, laughing, sleeping and a round of Imposter which Zheng created for us as his challenge.
A few minutes past midnight after a twenty minute walk with all our backpacks we finally arrived at our nice Airbnb.
Grateful for our arrival and exhausted from the day all of us fell asleep very quickly.

# 3 Day 2 - First Day in Krakow

After getting enough sleep we started our day by having breakfast together. Then we got ready and headed into the city center. After around twenty minutes by foot we arrived at the Krakow Main Square where we strolled over the Easter market, seeing many cool souvenirs and tasty food.

In the end I just bought a notebook for my sister as a present for when I come back home. Camille, Amy and Zheng then attended a german mess in a small church, while Lara, Nik and me went to explore a castle we saw on Google Maps.
When we arrived we learned that it's the Wawel castle and we learned about the legend of the Wawel dragon as well and were even able to see him breathe fire as well.

Wondering about the bricks with names and dates in the wall of the castle, which turned out to be names of donors for the restoration of the Wawel castle in the early 20th century, we found out that Krakow was occupied by Austria in the second half of the 19th century. Due to our hunger we decided to meet up with the others and get something to eat.
On our way back we saw some street artists doing an amazing breakdance show. Thereafter we went to a small place where we got to try Pierogi, mine were filled with potato and bacon bites and really tasty as well.
Strengthened by the delicious food we went back to show the others the cool dragon we found earlier and to sit on the with grass overgrown riverbanks of the Vistula river. Just before sunset we made our way back home to our Airbnb walking through a really nice park. After a small break we started cooking our dinner and let the evening wind down...

# 4 Day 3 - Jewish Krakow experience

We made our way to the Easter market again after having a relaxed morning.
On the market Amy and Camille bought some artificial flower wreaths, which looked pretty stylish.

With our two beautifully decorated girls we made our way to Kazimierz the Jewish quarter in Krakow. On our way we peaked into a few small vintage stores, where Camille got to buy new dungarees, perfectly fitting her style.
When we finally arrived in Kazimierz we were able to get a good a look into a synagogue and visit some tiny but cute Jewish bookstores, where Zheng even bought a book to learn hebrew. The only problem was, the book was written in polish and none of us speaks more than a few words Polish.

Driven by the cold wind and Camille's hunger we made our way to the next Zabka for Camille to get a snack and us to get closer to our actual goal, the Schindlers Museum. After crossing the Vistula we stood on the Ghetto Heroes Square, a square with lots of oversized metallic chairs on it. The Chairs were erected there in 2005 as a reminder of the jews who were crammed together with all their belongings on this place by the Nazis. It's called Heroes Square because tens of Germans were killed there during an revolt by brave jews during the second world war.
When we got to the Schindlers Museum we learned sadly that we wouldn't be able to go inside since we didn't prebook any tickets and the next few days were completely sold out. By then all of us got hungry and we decided to sit down in a nice place where we got to try potato pancakes with vegetable goulash and an amazing mango-passionfruit lemonade.

Strengthened by the tasty meal we made our way back to Kazimierz to walk a bit more through the area. Following the heritage route we walked past a few more synagogues to a nice square where you could buy Zapiekanka, a large Baguette with loads of various toppings, but all of us were too full by our lunch to try one, but we decided that we had to try them on one of the following days.
While returning to the apartment we stopped at the banksy museum but decided not to enter due to the high entrance fee of 18€per person. Back at the Airbnb we sat together and made plans for the next days and started to prebook the famous attractions of the following cities because we didn't want something like today with the Schindlers Museum to happen again.
In the evening we got to enjoy ourselves in a nice pub close to our apartment.

# 5 Day 4 - Another beautiful side of Krakow

After getting set and done for the day we made our way to a small daily local market with fresh vegetables, fruit and different polish traditions, much cheaper than on the Easter market the days before. Having bought a few snacks we went to the Town Hall Tower with a little museum inside. On the highest floor you had an amazing view over the city and especially the Wawel Castle - our next destination for that day. Headed for the Castle we stopped for an early lunch, first pierogi for some and then the promised Zapiekanka for others.

Afterwards we walked to the castle to show others the castle we had explored a few days before. On top we noticed that an area was open today none of us had seen before, it was another huge courtyard with paintings on the ceiling. On Monday we saw a fabulous lake on Google Maps we'd like to see in real life. Hence we crossed the nearest bridge over to

the other side of the Vistula to see the Wawel castle from the other side and to get closer to the lake.

After an estimated 30 minutes walk we arrived at the lake where we had to take a selfie session first.

We decided to take a stroll around the Zakrzowak. On our way we noticed some cigarette butts and beer mats lying around on the grass really close to a trashcan. We took a little break to clean up the place a little bit before continuing our tour around the lake.
A few minutes later we found a swing on which we enjoyed ourselves as if we were kids again. Having had a lot of fun the swing we went down to the lake on some platforms suited for swimming in the summer. While trying the temperature of the water which was quite cold by the way, Camille's sunglasses were blown into the lake by the strong wind tormenting us all day.
We took a few more pictures from the Zakrzowek and then raced up a ramp to get back on the track. We didn't stay on track for long because we found another amazing spot down at the lake to take some photos.

Due to Zheng's and Camille's tired legs we agreed on splitting the group for the rest of the days. Lara, Amy, Nik and I walked back in the direction of the castle whereas Camille and Zheng took a bus to the apartment. Since we were hungry and frozen when we got to the castle, we went to a nice small restaurant for dinner where we got to try sweet pierogi for the first time as dessert. We can only encourage you to try them yourselves when visiting Poland.
Interested in how the castle would look in the dark we took a little detour on our way back to the Airbnb. To be honest it wasn't that special.
As second dessert I got myself a chimney cake and Nik got himself an ice cream in the pedestrian zone we walked through.
Exhausted by far more than 20.000 steps we stayed that evening in and played some board game called Hitser. To my regret I wasn't able to beat Lara, just like the last time we played before the Trip.

# 6 Day 5 - Salty Wieliczka

Today all of us took our time, we weren't in a hurry, since our plan was to leave around twelve to take the bus to the Wieliczka Salt Mine. We used the time for a nice breakfast, shopping moisturizing cream and sending postcards to our friends and family back home. At quarter to twelve we took the bus, in Poland it's common to pay the bus by time and not by how many stations you need to go, that was new for all of us. After the 40 minute ride which cost us only around 1,20€we arrived at the salt mine in Wieliczka. Some of us got a little snack before entering the mines, since we were half an hour too early anyway. For entering the mines we had to walk many stairs downward, I believe it was 135 stairs to get to the first underground level at a depth of 65m. During the tour we learned a lot

of interesting facts about this mine and about salt mining in general. For example began salt mining in the mine we were visiting over 700 years ago, at a time when Poland was a pretty young country, since the Kingdom of Poland was only founded in the beginning of the 11th century. The Legend about the discovery of the mine speaks about a Hungarian princess, princess Kunigunde, who was married to duke Boleslaus of Krakow and since there was no salt in Poland at this time she asked her father for a salt mine as a wedding gift. Legend says she threw her engagement ring in her saltmine in Hungary and then commanded the miners in Poland to dig a shaft, and in the first crystal of salt they found was her wedding ring. Until now Kunigunde is the patron saint of the salt mine. That's why one of the many chapels the miners built underground is named after her. It was spectacular to get to visit this underground chapel. And if anyone of you is still looking for a special place to marry, you could even rent this salt mine chapel and marry underground.

We didn't only learn about legends and faith but about actual salt mining, we got to see how the salt was transported in the mines in big round blocks so you could roll them and as well the horse driven machinery which was used to move these blocks vertically to the ground. These horses even used to live underground and had underground stables built by the miners. Unlike the horses the miners got out of the mines at the end of every shift, no miner was actually living in the mines.
During the tour we walked only 3,5km of the round about 245km of tunnel and even this took us 2,5 hours to walk down there. After visiting the tunnels, licking the salty walls, admiring the underground salt lakes and learning about the famous people who had been in these mines before us, like Kopernikus, Chopin and Goethe, we ended our trip at a depth of 135m. When we were above ground again, we rested in a restaurant with a nice waitress named Olga who recommended a very tasty beer to camille. After dinner we returned home to Krakow and packed our stuff for our departure to Bratislava on the next day.

# 7 Day 6 - Travel to Bratislava

Bebeep-beep, bebeep-beep.
It's 7:30 and the alarm is going off, we start to awaken. Slowly.
Half an hour later the last of us got out of bed as well and we started with having breakfast. Afterwards we began to clean the apartment, which was a bit more difficult than expected, since we only had a dustpan and hand brush and no broom. Having packed the rest of our luggage and cleaned the Airbnb we left to the train station.

Saying our last goodbye to Krakow we left on time at 11:04.
The next two hours before our switch to the train to Bratislava we used for a more detailed feedback to our group dynamics, the planning of our first stop and our wishes and critics for the future ones.
In the next train most of us worked on this, our journal to keep it updated and correcting spelling errors, prepared some Instagram post with pictures from Krakow or updated their families about the wellbeing and the experiences of this trip so far.
The train ride felt like an eternity but eventually after six hours we arrived in Bratislava at around 5p.m..
It took us about twenty minutes to walk to our hostel, the urban elephant hostel. Everyone who is out for an amazing social time, meeting great new open-minded people and a lot of fun should definitely consider a visit here. They've got a daily program starting with the opportunity of a lunch cooked by one of the staff members, which are always travellers as well and then many different activities during the day up to a pub crawl following a home-cooked vegan dinner for everyone, who wanted to join.
We decided to join the dinner for 5€each and met a bunch of amazing new people. Afterwards Camille, Nik, Lara and me participated in the pub crawl, the special this evening, it was a kinky pub crawl...
...
IT WAS LOTS OF FUN!!!

# 8 Day 7 - One week over, two more to come

Today we got up after sleeping in, or at least most of us did. Someone not to be named here, preferred to stay in bed with a headache and nausea. Of course this had nothing to do with the previous night.
My day started with a nice hot shower, then Amy and I started walking around the city center and looking at some older, beautiful buildings. After a while Nik texted that he wanted to join us, but after sending him our location he somehow managed to walk in the completely different direction, so we continued our trips as two.
Walking towards the UFO, a fancy restaurant and lookout point above the Danube river which we wanted to visit at a later date, we came across many souvenir shops and small little cafes.
Which by the way make nearly half the shops in the pedestrian zone. Sadly we couldn't find anything to our liking to shop, but we were thrown back into our childhood since half of the shops sold plush toys of the little mole from the series of the same name. But no one of us was interested in spending at least 10€on a little plushy.
Before grabbing lunch at the local burger king, since Mc Donalds didn't have any vegetarian options we tried to get the hungover person out of bed. Even after puking twice she wasn't ready to leave the hostel so we went as two again.
After a lot of rest Lara finally joined us for a walk around the city and the exploration of some more souvenir shops. In the evening the three of us spent like an hour to find a restaurant with more than the one obligatory veggie dish, but the one we chose in the end was not bad, basic but good. Still tired and exhausted from the day before we decided to skip partying today.

# 9 Day 8 - A w(o/a)nderful day

Leaving the hostel at quarter past ten we made our way to the next bus bringing us to Devin. In Devin we first went to see Devin castle, or at least what once was Devin Castle. Nowadays it's more the ruins of a castle.

But the nature around and the ruins itself were every bit of the 3€worth we spend on the entry. After taking enough photos to probably make a own photo album from them, we parted from Zheng and started our hike towards the ruins of the close air defense base from the soviets from the times of the Cold war. We hiked a quite steep way uphill for like 2,5 hours, including some drinking and snacking and photo breaks of course. It was more exhausting to me than expected especially since I carried most of the snacks and the water, but the view from up top definitely was worth every bit of sweat.

We had an amazing view from Bratislava all around to the nearby Devins Castle with the Danube in the background. It took us a while until we had enough from the view and headed downhill again. We agreed on taking another route down towards the neighboring town and going home by bus from there. On the way we found some improvised sporting equipment like horizontal bar in between two trees where all of us had a very small workout.

Afterwards we decorated ourselves with some flowers from the forest and hiked to the bus stop. Four and a half hours after the start at Devin Castle we took the bus back to our hostel. There we joined the communal evening meal since it was potato chickpea curry for 5€. Thereafter we rested for a while and joined another pubcrawl.

# 10 Day 9 - Not everything is always sunshine

Sunday - Sadly no sun. But we got out of the hostel for a really nice breakfast.

On our way to the bistro we passed a marathon which had started that morning and was still going on after we had finished our breakfast.
Afterwards we made our way to the castle in Bratislava, which to be honest wasn't that impressive. From my point of view it lacked a bit of colour and most of the garden was just green bushes and no flowers. We didn't go inside so it might be different if you do, but the visit was worth anyway due to the great view you had over the city and the Danube - even if it was still really cloudy, mirroring my mood during the day because of the happenings of the last night.
Then we headed for a monument erected to commemorate the fallen soldiers of the UDSSR. I think it was pretty impressive especially since there were gravestones, not only ingraved with names of the fallen soldiers, but their dates of birth and death as well.

I am normally used to mass graves with a universal gravestone to commemorate the fallen ones. I walked home with Lara and due to a lot of talking I felt way better but still not really good yet. But after going for a solo stroll in the evening and having dinner on my own and a bit time for myself I felt good again. So always remember even if you travel in a group sometimes you just need to take some me-time and privacy to stay happy. After my dinner Amy, Lara and Nik joined me and we strolled together through the city center at night and took some pictures with the statues Bratislava is known for.

Walking back to our hostel we went down a trip a memory lane talking about series we watched as kids and listening to songs from these series. We ended our day by playing a short round of skyjo during which I already fell half asleep and Lara drew with a pen on my body.

# 11 Day 10 - A relaxed finale for Bratislava

We had breakfast at the hostel this time and then as a group of three Nik, Lara and me walked to the President's garden, a nice park in the back of the President's residence. There were really beautiful flowers and the atmosphere was just great.

Shortly before leaving we saw a P.E. teacher entering the park with his students, they needed to run rounds in the park. All of us were a bit irritated since it was only boys. Then we went back to the hostel stopping at an apothecary on the way to get some medicine for Lara since she was feeling a bit sick and had a sore throat.
We relaxed for a while in the hostel and then I went for a walk with Amy, we took a break at one of the little cafes Bratislava had so many of. I had a really nice elderflower lemonade with a piece of delicious straciatella cake while Amy enjoyed her fabulous hot chocolate with cinnamon. Meanwhile Nik came to the cafe and we continued our walk as three. Finished with our walk we shopped some souvenirs at the local shops and snacks and some tea for Lara at the Lidl.
Amy and I used the rest of the afternoon to plan our days in budapest so we would have a rough idea what to do when and combine with what.
Next to our hostel there was this nice small restaurant called Huy Vege we wanted to try

since the start, but never got to do so. That's why we went there for dinner and I think all of us were sad, that we didn't get to go a second time. It was delicious and really cheap as well.
We spend our evening with packing and resting, while Lara and me were proofreading the first part of the bachelor thesis from a friend of ours. Somehow we had very much fun doing so and visualising what we were reading.

## 12 Day 11 - Our Trip to Budapest

We woke up, packed our stuff and then left the hostel room, so we didn't have to pay a fine. Our luggage safely stored in the luggage room we enjoyed our breakfast waited until it was time for us to head to the train station. Zheng left a bit earlier to get an early lunch for himself since he didn't like to have breakfast with us.
As a group of five we walked roughly half an hour with our backpacks until we got to the train station. Once there we were informed that our train had already a delay of 10 minutes. Lucky for us we booked the train without a train change in between and so none of us were in a hurry.

During the ride we worked on different things, a few on their posts and stories with pictures of the previous days for instagram or polarsteps, others did some uni stuff, due to the fact that the semester had started again. Two and a half hours later we arrived in Budapest. Our first task was to find a spot were we could pick up our prebooked budapest cards. Of course it wasn't possible in the train station itself as Camille told us the day before when we explicitly asked her about that. So we took our backpacks and walked 25 minutes to the nearest pickup point. Lucky for us it was the same way as when we would have walked to our apartment, that's why all of us except Camille decided to walk the

remaining 15 minutes to the flat instead of taking the metro, so we didn't have to pay or activate our cards already.
When we arrived in the Airbnb we had a discussion about who gets to sleep where. It was quite difficult and annoying because Zheng wasn't okay with sleeping in the same room as a girl and Camille had set her mind on one specific bed she wanted. After five minutes of arguing and Camille not getting her favorite bed she was a bit sulky. That's why Nik, Lara, Amy, Star a friend of Niks from the other group who came to visit us and me got out to find something to eat.
Pretty fast we agreed on Langos, the only difficulty was to find a nice place where the prices weren't too high and obviously a tourist trap. We walked by several places where the Langos should cost round about 20€before we got to a nice place with acceptable prices. And not only the price was great, the flavour as well.

Amy, Lara and me headed home afterwards due to the fact the washing machine we had turned on before leaving was finished, while Nik and Star continued strolling through the city. For this evening Lara, Amy and me had planned to take a night cruise on the Danube, which was included in our budapest cards. Seeing all the famous and large Buldings at night with great illumination before getting to see them from close up the next days was fantastic.

45 minutes later the Cruise ended there were it had started, which left us with a 30 minute walk back to the flat. Being back the apartment we only got ready for bed and fell asleep.

## 13 Day 12 - Walking in Buda, walking in Pest

We wanted to pick up Amy at the Parliament at 10 since she had booked a visit there, lucky for us we always take a bit longer than expected, that's why all of us except Amy were still at the flat, when we got the message to upload yesterday of our Journal by noon. After the submission we went into the city where our first goal the St. Stephans Basilica was, next to the anyway beautiful streets of course. Ego sum via veritas et vita - the inscription on the basilica which means as much as "I am the way into truth and life". We had to wait a little while before we could see the basilica from upfront because there was a movie shoot and the place was blocked off. But it was definitely worth the wait.

Afterwards went to see Margaret Island, which is more like a really big park surrounded by the Danube. Enjoying the sun, we decided to have lunch at a place called Hippie Island, where the menus where named after famous bands and musicians like the one I had - Led Zeppelin - it was a ham and cheese toast with fries. Lara then went home to rest due to a feeling of sickness, the rest of us strolled around the Island for a while longer.
We found some old ruins, belonging to the residency of saint margaret of hungary. She grew up as a nun, after her father the king of hungary vowed that he would give up his child to the religion if hungary was liberated from the mongols, which happened in 1245.

After that we went to see an old church on the Island
and then the Japanese garden. During that time Nik and I had a lot of fun teasing Amy about a boy she was texting with. During the way down from the island we agreed to split up, because Camille and Zheng wanted to go back to the flat whereas Amy, Nik and me went to the side of Buda.
Seeing Pest from the other side of the Danube was amazing especially the view of the parliament was breathtaking and a great opportunity to take some pictures.

Our next planned stop was the Royal Palace but we made some stops in between to take a break and enjoy the view over the city since we were walking uphill most of the time The Royal Palace itself wasn't that impressive once we stood infront of it since you couldn't see it completely because it was too large to grasp how majestic the building is. But I got a cold pepsi there which made me quite happy since it had gotten really warm during the day. After taking many pictures - more of the view than the Royal Palace - we walked around a little and came by a nice street where the cherries were blooming. From there you had an amazing view over the part from Buda you usually don't see because there aren't that many tourist attractions but it was beautiful nevertheless.

Due to tired legs Amy and Nik decided to take the tram while I took a walk back home. Once everyone was home we went to the Aldi next door to buy groceries for a lentil bolognese. During the cooking I headed out once more to buy a hot water bottle for Lara, which was more of challenge than it first seemed. I had to go to the Rossmann where they usually sell these, after overcoming a few language barrier problems I didn't only learn that hot water bottle means forró vizes palack, but that Rossmann here doesn't have any. So I went to dm on the other side of the street, same problem. Then I went to the apothecary - closed. Lucky for me there was another one round the corner where I could finally buy one. In the end we had really tasty lentil bolognese and afterwards we went to bed - Lara, now happier then before but still feeling sick, with her new hot water bottle.

## 14 Day 13 - The Gellert Hill

I woke up, the others, who were already awake for a while wanted to leave soon. So I got myself ready, skipped breakfast and we headed out as four. Lara still resting in Bed and Zheng on his way to an activity he had prebooked for himself. A five minute walk to the danube and then across it with the nearest bridge, then we stood in front of the Gellert Hill, named after Gerard of Csanad, a monk and first bishop of Csanad who was killed by people opposing the Christianization of hungary in the 11th century. After a few meters uphill we found the entrance to a church in the hill, but we didn't go inside since we weren't too eager to pay after having already seen a church undergound in Krakow. So we continued our hike to the top with a few breathing breaks in between because it was way steeper than it looked in the beginning. Of course we took one or two of the obligatory pictures of the view as well.

When we finally arrived at the top we admired not only the statue but the many colourful flowers which were planted there as well. We strolled around up there and enjoyed the

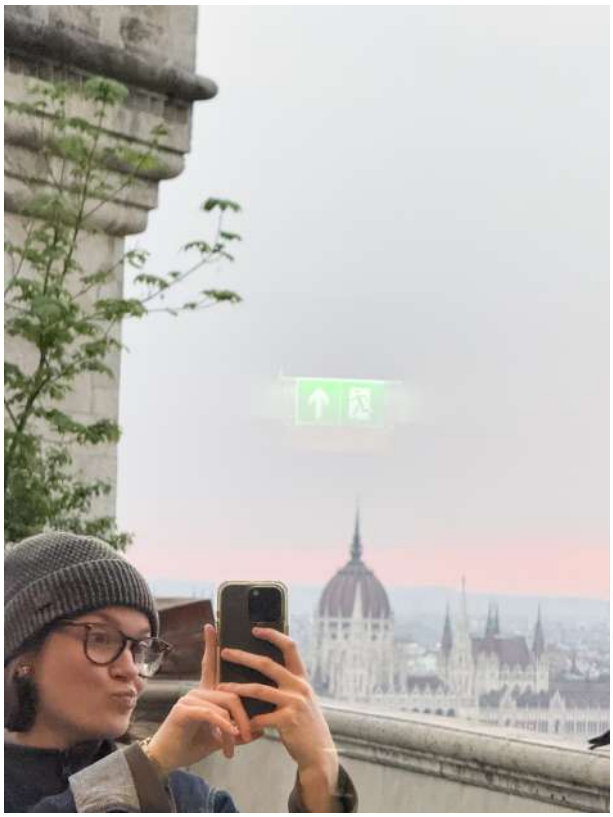
view and the sun for about half an hour until we went back home again. Back at the flat again we got rid of our jackets and pullovers we wore during the morning and bought something to eat for Lara. After a break for about an hour Nik Amy and I went out again to see more of the city, but 5 minutes later Nik left us with the intention to see the national Museum inclueded in our budapest card, while Amy and I went for lunch. It took us a some time before we settled for Langos again, this time at Grannys Langos where we even got a free Langos donut for dessert.

Filled with Langos up to the top we walked through the city a bit more towards the Dohany street synagogue. On arrival we learned that this synagogue was the largest in Europe and the second largest in the world.
Nonetheless we agreed on not going inside for the price of round about 35€. Meanwhile Nik joined us and agreed as well. We walked not for long as three since Nik who hadn't had Lunch yet was quite hungry while Amy and I couldn't even think about eating more anytime soon. Just the two us continued our journey through the city straight towards the moon we wanted to hold.

Exhausted by this powerful lift we went back to the flat where a group talk waited for us. We talked about some issues in the group and problems with camilles style of being a group leader as well. Thereafter we went, still as friends, to another night cruise since Nik, Camille and Zheng hadn't been yet. By some reason this cruise was 15 minutes longer than the cruise we did on our first evening. I decided to not join the others on the tram back to our flat afterwards but to take a walk to get two chimney cakes one for Lara and one for me. After this deicious evening treat all of us went to bed pretty quick because we wanted get up at 4 at the next morning to see the sunrise.

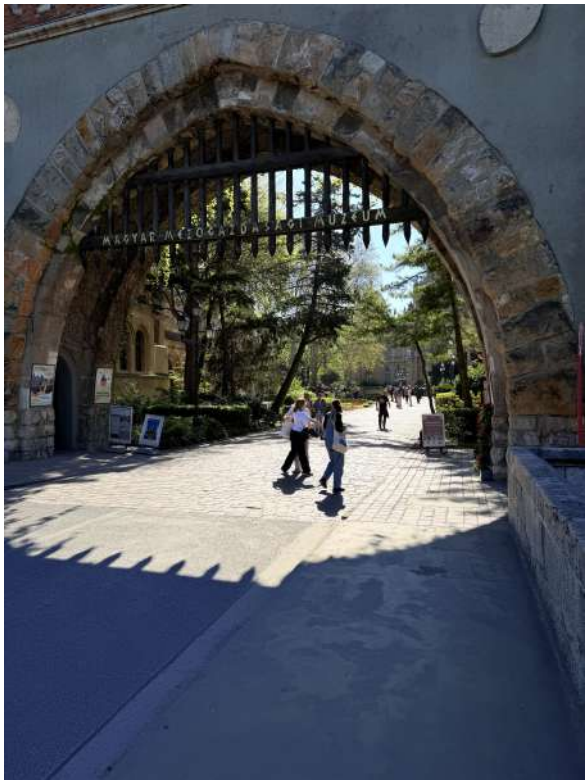
# 15 Day 14 - This didn't go as planned

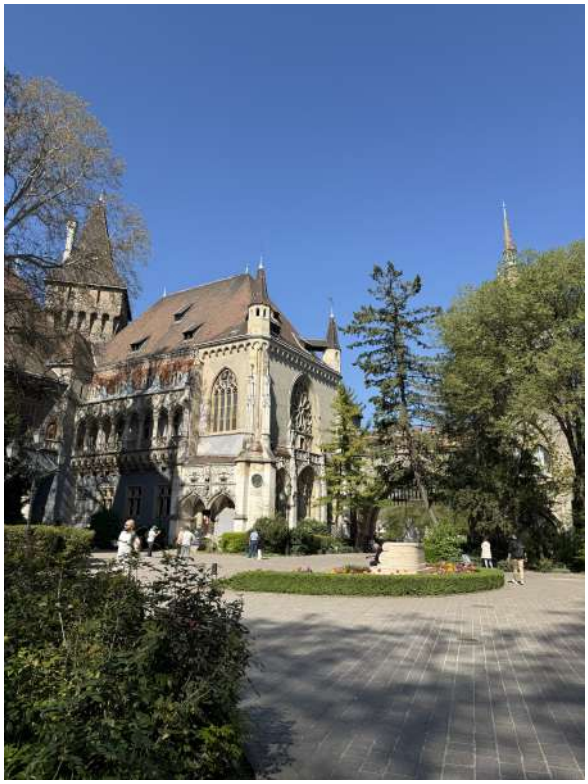
My alarm went off at 4:15 and Lara sat completely awake next to like it wasn't in the middle of the night. We took 20 minutes to get ready to leave and all six of us made our way to the tram station to get to the fisherman's bastion since no one wanted to walk an hour to get there. When we arrived a few minutes past 5:00 we were impressed by the view even most of the city was dark. We chose today because the sky was supposed to be clear but of course the horizon was clouded. Nevertheless we enjoyed round about two hours up there taking pictures, admiring the breathtaking view or just walking around there. We must have taken like a thousand photos while being there, some of them really aesthatic and others a bit funny.



When the sun was risen behind the clouds we headed back to the flat. On our way we we stopped at the Aldi to get ourselves stuff to make sandwiches for today because we wanted to make a day trip to the Szechenyi thermal bath. So after a bit of resting, preparing and packing all of us except Zheng took the metro to the place of heroes which was close to the thermal baths. To our disappointment we learned that the main statue and the symbol of this place, the statue of archangel gabriel was under restauration and

not there. That's why we didn't take long to head for the castle in the park lying in front of us. While walking through the yard it felt like we were in a fairy tale, it was really beautiful. Astonished by the fact that the castle was a museum today, for some reason the national museum of agriculture, we finally headed for the baths.





Entering the baths we were informed by signs that self brought food wasn't allowed to be consumed here, which made our sandwiches a bit useless. Lara, Amy and me went from pool to pool looking for a silent resting area like we were used to from german spas to take a nap and catch up to the missed sleep of last night. A bit frustrated by the fact that the only loungers existing there were outside and all taken, we went for the salt sauna and then back to the pools. Sad that the baths weren't what we expected with no resting area and actually not that good looking pools and walls as on the pictures on the internet lara and I already left around noon and headed back to flat since Lara wasn't feeling that good again. Both of us straight went to bed for a short nap. Or not that short to be honest. I woke up two and a half hours later and then spent some time on my macbook mostly doing uni stuff. During our sleep the others had returned as well but while Amy and Nik were taking a walk somewhere outside enjoying the sun Camille went for a nap as well. One and a half hour later then me Lara woke up as well and we ate some of the leftover lentil bolognese with pine cone croquettes. Later that evening Nik asked us if we wanted to go out with him to the ruin bars but we were all missing the energy for that. So all of us just relaxed in our beds done by the day.

## 16 Day 15 - A bit of this, a bit of that

This morning was chill, we all slept in and once everyone was awake, Nik, Camille, Amy and me went to a memorial of a theater or something like that with statues of some actors.

It was half an hour walk to get there, but all of us enjoyed being in the sun. Once arrived we realised that there was not really that much to do except looking at these statues and take pleasure in the sun.
There was this one statue pointing somewhere and Amy wanted to point back, but wasn't big enough, that's why I took her on my shoulders.

Like this we started to go back to the flat. This time we walked by the Danube to appreciate the view with this nice weather. After a short while I let Amy down again and Nik and me played a little bit of Pokemon Go, which we had downloaded on this travel but didn't really get to play.
As we arrived at the flat again Lara and me continued proofreading the bachlor thesis of a friend of ours. We were only able to do one chapter before Lara fell asleep again. Meanwhile Nik and Amy went to a park somewhere for lying in the grass and enjoying the sun.
In the afternoon I met with the two of them to get a chimney cake. On my way there I phoned with my mum who was really happy to hear from me since I had only called once since the beginning of the trip. - So take out your phone now and call your parents, grandparents or other loved ones. - Nik and I decided to have an ice cream with a chimney cake cone while Amy had a cinnamon one with nutella. We walked by the Danube where we sat in the sun.
As we were just ready to leave back to the apartment, a friend of mine, Jessica from another travel group called me since they had arrived in budapest today as well and we wanted to meet up. So we stayed at the river a bit longer until Jessica and Shiv the group leader of the other group arrived. While walking around and showing them some highlights that were close by we talked about our experiences on the trips so far. It was really nice to hear how it was going in the other group and what they had experienced

so far. We decided to have dinner together at a pizza place close to our Airbnb. I got a little bit too late because I got some stuff for Lara first and then gave her some company before I went for pizza. It was quite cheap and really delicious.
Afterwards Jessica, Carolin, another friend from the other group, Shiv, Camille, Nik and I headed out for a ruin bar. First we wanted to go to the most famous one, the Szimpla Kert but once we got there and saw the line we decided to go to another. The Macska??? was the one we settled for because someone had recommended it to Camille. It was a cosy nice place where we sat on carpets upstairs. I had just one coke and then went back to the flat because I was really tired from the day. Once arrived a went straight for bed.

# 17 Day 16 - Let's go to Vienna

After I woke up I instantly started packing since there was only one and a half hour left until we had to leave the flat. Before finalizing my packing I took a shower. Then we started cleaning. It wasn't that easy hence the lack of packing from other team members. For example I had to remind our teamleader three times to get her food out of the fridge or pack her top as well which was hanging on the clothesline. After a lot of stress but acting calm we got to leave the apartment ten minutes late after remembering last second that there were still some spaghetti in the cupboard.
Then we went to the Metro to get to the Kelenfoeld train station from which our train departed. Due to the fact that we were ten minutes early I got myself some breakfast at a local bakery. Even though Lara told me twice she didn't want something I got her and Amy a cocoa snail which they were very happy about.

Once in the train we had to sit on the ground because we didn't want to spend money on non-mandatory reservations and the train was fully booked. Just Lara was lucky to

get the last seat available in our compartment. We spent most of the time with resting because some of us didn't return as early from last night as I did. At the next station many passengers left so we could finally get seats for all of us. Before arrival Amy and I once again had to explain Camille what kind of bullshit she had planned. She didn't even know at which station we had to get of the train or how to get from there to the apartment. As our train arrived we faced the next problem. Our vienna city cards which include 72 hours of discounts for various attractions and 7 days of free travel were bought with a start date of tomorrow. That's why each of us had to pay more than 3€to use the subway to get to our stay. There we encountered another problem because Camille wasn't able to do the online check-in which she should have done already before arrival. But once Lara and I took the matter in our own hands and we got the necessary information from Camille we checked us in and entered the rooms. Our nine squaremeter large rooms for 3 people each left barely space to place all of the backpacks.
While the others rested, Amy, Lara and I went out to explore the city. First we walked to the Stephans Dome and then by the palace of Franz Josef.

Afterwards we passed the Hofburg and decided to have dinner in an vegan restaurant around the corner called veggiezz. We enjoyed our meals and headed back to our stay then.

# 18 Day 17 - The classical Vienna experience

For breakfast we went to Cafe Demel, a very famous but really expensive cafe. All of us had amazing Kaiserschmarrn.

After this luxury for our taste buds we went through the Demel shop downstairs but since none of us had the interest of spending any more money we didn't buy anything of the overpriced luxury goods. So we made our way to the next stop. Passing by the Sisi museum once more like yesterday we went into the national library where to our disappointment, we learned that the State Hall we wanted to visit wasn't open on Mondays. That's why we split up, while Camille and Zheng went to see the Kapuzinergruft, the rest of us went to see the parliament. Unlike the parliament in Budapest this one was for free and so we went inside.

We spent about one and a half hour inside until we had to leave since they were closing. Due to the fact that it just had started raining, we agreed on skipping the city hall and head the the Butterfly House next. There we met Camille and Zheng. But since Zheng didn't want to spend any money to see Butterflies, he left again while we entered the house. The butterflies in different colours and size were amazing and definitely worth every penny we spent. Even the house wasn't that big we spent a lot of time in there taking photos and enjoying the butterflies. After these gorgeous animals driven by hunger we went to the Naschmarkt. there we lost Camille at the next best restaurant, while we continued to walk over the market. We were spoiled with free nuts and falafel by the merchants.
Once we had seen the whole market we went for the Karlskirche next, where we learned that there was a classical concert this evening. We took a flyer just in case.
Amy and Nik wanted to walk the city a bit more while Lara and I needed a little bit of rest. So the two of us went to the apartments to relax a bit. But since I hadn't eaten that much on the market I was already hungry again and went to five guys on my own. I really enjoyed the little break from the others, my music and a tasty meal.
When I got back to our stay I had about 30 minutes to relax as well until Amy and Nik came back. That's when Lara, Amy and me booked tickets for tonights classical concert at the Karls church. For 26€for a student it seemed like a very fair price. That's how I got to my first classical concert and heard the four seasons of vivaldi in full for the first time. It was pretty amazing and I enjoyed all of it. The acoustics were great and the church itself was amazing as well.

After this amazing evening we went home to our apartments and pretty straight to bed.

# 19 Day 18 - A lot of Art

We started the day pretty relaxed, I took a shower and went then to get some bread for everyone for breakfast. It's been a while since we sat together and had breakfast at one of our stays together. Once finished we had to hurry a bit afterall because we had booked our entry to the Belvedere Palace at eleven. It took us half an hour to get there. As we stepped onto the grounds we were impressed by the big garden and the colourful flowers but since we were in a hurry a bit we kept this view for later.
Lucky for us there was no line so we could enter the Palace quick without having to wait outside in the cold wind. After locking our stuff in the lockers and going to the toilet we started our journey through the art eras. Our first impression was a carpet made of lavender flowers which was located right before the oldest paintings in the Palace dating back to the 13th century. Nearly every of the paintings and sculptures from this time had something to do with Jesus or other christian religious figures. Since no one of us was really that religious this wasn't the art we were interested in. That's why after already a short while we went to the first floor where the paintings from the baroque period were displayed. All of a sudden we found ourselves in a gigantic marble hall with an amazing ceiling painting.

After taking many pictures, especially for social media for the girls, we continued through the palace to see more paintings. The most fun we had with sculptures depicting different face expression. Of course we had to recreate all of these expressions.

Thereafter we went though the section of still lifes up to the section where the more famous artists were displayed. We saw some Monets, Biedermeiers, Renoirs and of course Gustav Klimt. There were many Klimt paintings, the Kiss and Judith among many others.

While Nik, Amy, Lara and me were looking at the paintings of the great masters, Camille and Zheng had left the Belvedere to get lunch. Two or three rooms after the Klimts I found my most favourite picture of the whole exhibition. It was called "Falling Leaves" and was painted in 1899 by Olga Wisinger-Florian.

In the same room Amy found her favourite painting as well. It was a Monet from which she even bought a poster at the end of our tour. The last floor was filled with more modern art and since only Lara was interested in that and we had already spent 3,5 hours in the Palace we didn't take that long to go through there.
Once we had seen all of the art we went outside to admire the architecture of the upper Belvedere with the lake in front of it.

Even as we left the grounds we weren't done with our day full of art. We took the bus to the Hundertwasser Village right next to the Hundertwasser house. To our disappointment it didn't look as cool as it did on the internet. That's why we stayed maybe ten minutes until going to a close restaurant to have a late lunch.
Once we were filled up by our Lunch we headed for the Prater. There we were disappointed as well, for one by the outrageous prices but due to the early time of the season some of the cool attractions were still closed or in repair. All in all it seemed a bit like a lost place, but we tried one of the rides anyway and it was fun, even though I felt a bit nauseous afterwards. We decided to go back to our stay after this ride so we could rest a bit.
When it was dark outside we went outside once more to go to the museum of change, an outdoor light show, which was really amazing.

We sat there for about half an hour until we got cold. Then Lara, Nik, Amy and me went to the nearest shop that was still open after 8 p.m. which were online a few. Lara got herself a bowl, while we others preffered a Mc Donalds menu. After that we went home and then straight to sleep.

## 20 Day 19 - The last of Vienna

Yesterday Lara asked me to motivate her to get out of bed a bit quicker than the days before. That's what I did or tried to do. It took me 20 minutes to get her out of there. After this fight with her motivation we had breakfast. Then Lara had to get herself ready to leave but since she hated it if someone was waiting for her, Camille, Nik, Amy and I went to Augarten alone. We visited Camilles old work place, some porcelain shop and then strolled around the garden for a bit. Our next stop for that day was the anchor clock, an imposing clock. On our way there Lara joined us, while Camille left for lunch with former collegue of hers.

Amy, Lara and I wanted to visit the State Hall of the National Library but Nik wasn't interested and left us. We didn't visit the library for the exhibition but for the great ceiling paintings and the gigantic awesome looking bookshelves. Again we took many photos of course some for social media as well.

Afterwards we strolled through some fancy looking passages Lara had found on Instagram towards the city hall. It was nice to see the impressive city hall up close but it didn't take us long to walk past it, since we were quite hungry. On our way to get lunch we passed a military act for a state reception for someone from north macedonia. Amy wanted to have Kaiserschmarrn from Demel once more while Lara and I wanted to get us something at the Billa next door. But we left only with a drink for me because of the horrendous prices. So Lara got herself a veggie Lahmacun and I got myself two hotdogs. Just as we finished our lunch Nik joined the three of us. As four we started our journey through the shops selling the luxury sweets, starting with Lindt where I got myself some chocolate, followed by Heindl for Mozartkugeln and then Manner for some waffles. Nik got himself a magnet from one of the souvenir shops as well. As we wanted to head to our stay we remembered the blue tomato shop nearby. So we took a little time to look through the sale section where Lara found a perfectly fitting jacket. With our purchases of the afternoon we went home to get some rest.

An hour of rest was enough, then Lara, Amy and I sat on the Danube next to our stay for twenty minutes until we made our way to Velani, a restaurant Lara had found on our way to Vienna where they serve all of the traditional austrian dishes but in vegan. After half an hour of subway we arrived at the restaurant where Camille was already waiting for us. All of us were enchanted by the delicious dinner. Even though we were completely filled by the main course some of us couldn't resist dessert.

On our way back we stopped by the votiv church to see the light installation from Billi Thanner. It was a golden infinity sign made of light around the towers of the church. Really beautiful and perfect for pictures.

From there we walked home to our rooms, packed our backpacks and went to bed one last time on our journey.

# 21 Day 20 - The return of the Travellers

I started the last day with oversleeping. Lucky for me Nik woke me up thirty minutes before departure. I hurried in the shower, finalized my packing and then we headed out, straight to the Vienna West train station. There we boarded our train to Munich.

We were lucky that the train wasn't completely booked like the last one because we didn't book any seats again. On the four hours to Munich Lara and Amy worked on their Uni dues while I was working on my Journal. Due to a lot of delay our half an hour of transition time in munich shrank to only five minutes. So we had to hurry a lot at the train to get our connecting train to Kaiserslautern, which thwarted our plans to buy lunch at the munich train station. On the second train we ate the snacks we had left from the days before as lunch and continued our journal work. Once arrived in Kaiserslautern it didn't take us long to say our goodbyes since all of us were eager to get home. But of course we took one final group picture.

Willkommen... Welcome
Bienvenue
Wer uns findet, findet uns gut!
Mobilitätszentrale
VRN
DB
Geldautomat
Fahrkarten

## 22 Summary of Krakow

Krakow was an amazing city with lots of history and culture and great food of course. I myself was most fascinated by how clean this city is for its round about 800.000 citizens. You would barely see any trash, cigarette buds or gum on the street as sadly so often unusual in larger cities nowadays. Interesting was as well how this city got shaped by two different religions. Especially due to Easter and the Eastermarkets the christianity of the city with its many churches was shown but on the other hand the many synagogues in the Jewish city and all of the memorials commemorating the crimes against the Jews committed by the nazis. From my point of view Krakow is a great example that different religions doesn't need to be a point of conflict but more an opportunity for growth in freedom, society and humanity, and that in fact we are all just people living in harmony no matter our religious beliefs. In summary I can only recommend visiting Krakow for a few days with highlights like the saltmines and pierogi and of course Auschwitz as well if you book it in advance.

## 23 Summary of Bratislava

Definitely nice to visit, but not as good as Krakow. Everything what you want or need to see is pretty close and there aren't that many interesting things to do. I'd recommend if you just want to visit the city for the city's sake you plan 1-2 nights. On the other hand having five days in this hostel is a lot of fun. The Team of travellers who work there were all amazing and the daily activities were always a great opportunity for meeting new open-minded people. If you want to meet new exciting people and party a bit The Elephant hostels are a good point to head for. Then it's really nice to spend more than one night as well.

## 24 Summary of Budapest

Budapest is my most favourite eastern European metropolis I have visited so far. It made me a fan not only due to the impressive and beautiful artistic designed buildings. The food was amazing as well. And the atmosphere walking through the streets and parks is fantastic as well. And not only does the city provide great cultural and culinary experiences for your daytime city trip, but if you are out for fun there are a lot of great pubs and clubs to spend the nights meeting some of the many young people living in Budapest. My personal highlight still remains the Danube cruise by night and seeing the buildings illuminated even though the sunrise at fisherman's bastion might be able to compete if the sky and the horizon are clear.
So if you are looking for a destination for your next family holiday or a city to go hog wild with your buddies Budapest is a great choice and for Interrail it's the perfect mix of everything.

## 25 Summary of Vienna

It's close but for me Vienna was the best city on our route. From the architecture and the looks of the buildings alone it is clear that Vienna has a past of wealth and tradition. The perfect city if you love museums of history and art. But even if you don't, like me,

it's still amazing. There are many Palaces and Parks you can visit inside of the city even though you are for some reason not allowed to step on the grass in most of the parks, which from point of view is a bit ridiculous. But with fancy comes pricy as well so you should bring some money on your trip here. One more thing that is nice to mention about Vienna is, that there are many vegan or vegetarian restaurants, so if you are not a fan of eating meat it's easy to find something to eat unlike in some of the others cities before.

# 26 Summary of my Impressions, the social experiences and my personal growth

First of all I have to thank the European Commission and of course the IJBK e.V. who made this journey possible for me. I think my Journal depicts many of my impressions of this trip even if sometimes the bumps we had aren't mentioned. But that is part of the experience. No one could expect that if you throw 6 strangers or for me in this case two friends and three strangers on a train and let them travel Europe for three weeks, that everything goes smoothly. I think for myself I've learned a lot about tolerating different forms of behavior and manners from different areas all over the world, even I didn't always like them. Throughout the journey all of us learned how hard it is to communicate to make such a group work. It's way more coordination and compromise than you might think at first, but we handled it pretty well. I don't think that all of us will stay in touch for long after this experience but we for sure will always have a connection through this journey together. Personally I'm not sure if I would like to do a trip like this again, but I can say with certainty that I do not regret to have taken this opportunity for this experiences. I'll probably stick to travelling solo or in a duo and make vacations in a bigger group.